surviving men, managed to break contact and withdraw. The survivors from the second platoon of Delta Company, under the command of Second Lieutenant Kutty, also extricated themselves along the Tsangdhar-Karpo-la track. Shrikent decided to take his party and head for the drop zone and the advance medical station, but found the route cut off by the Chinese. He then tried to head for Brigade HQ but was met by the battalion 2IC, Major Charak, who told him the enemy had already overrun the position.

The group by now had been forced off the track, and the going was agonizingly difficult. They were still in the vicinity of the battle and rearguards were constantly engaging the pursuing Chinese. Unable to take any more of the jolting passage and realizing that in trying to save their CO the others were likely to get killed, Ahluwalia ordered Charak to abandon him. Leaving a wounded commanding officer behind was unheard of in the Indian Army, but to the officers in the party it must have seemed like there was no alternative. At that time, no one had any idea of how the Chinese would treat their POWs, but if Ahluwalia was to have any chance of survival, only the Chinese medics could provide him with the required attention. Charak had the stretcher placed on a prominent rock, took a rifle and stuck it into the ground by its bayonet, and then wrapped Ahluwalia's turban around the butt of the rifle. Leaving the CO with a water bottle and a rifleman who was to break off the moment the Chinese saw the wounded officer, the Gorkha party moved on.

Meanwhile, some men had found a hideout just below the drop zone into which the various Gorkha parties and some others congregated. They decided to stay there for the rest of the day, to take stock of the situation. At least seven officers (including Lieutenant Colonel Tewari from the Signals and Captain Mahabir Prasad from 1 Sikh) were either killed or missing, along with three JCOs and 190 other ranks.

In the next few days, small groups tried to take the Karpo-la track but were thwarted by the Chinese. Most of the survivors were too stunned to fight any more, intent only on surviving the elements and evading the Chinese. However, there were some incredible acts of bravery. Subedar Bhab Bahadur Khatwal and fifteen men of 1/9 GR rushed a Chinese MMG with the age-old war cry of 'Ayo Gorkhali'. There was the incessant chatter of the Chinese machine gun and then there was silence, as all the men from the party were mowed down. Small parties did make it through the Chinese